

Problems In Group Theory

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Contents

1	Basic Group Theory	1
1.1	Introduction	1

Chapter 1

Basic Group Theory

1.1 Introduction

Problem 1.1.1. Determine which of the following binary operations are associative:

1. the operation on $\mathbb{Z}$ defined by $a * b = a - b$
2. the operation on $\mathbb{R}$ defined by $a * b = a + b + ab$
3. the operation on $\mathbb{Q}$ defined by $a * b = \frac{a+b}{5}$
4. the operation on $\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}$ defined by $(a, b) * (c, d) = (ad + bc, bd)$
5. the operation on $\mathbb{Q} - \{0\}$ defined by $a * b = \frac{a}{b}$

Proof. This exercise is pretty trivial as we just have to compute $a * (b * c) = (a * b) * c$. For 1., $a * (b * c) = a * (b - c) = a - (b - c) = a - b + c$ but $(a * b) * c = (a - b) * c = (a - b) - c = a - b - c$. Rest of them are pretty similar. $\square$

Problem 1.1.2. Prove that addition of residue classes in $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is associative.

Proof. By definition of residue addition,

$$[a] + [b] = [a + b]$$

Therefore, we get the following.

$$\begin{aligned} [a] + ([b] + [c]) &= [a] + [b + c] \\ &= [a + (b + c)] \\ &= [(a + b) + c] \\ &= [a + b] + [c] \\ &= ([a] + [b]) + [c] \end{aligned}$$

$\square$

Problem 1.1.3. Prove that multiplication of residue classes in $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is associative.

Proof. By definition of residue multiplication,

$$[a] \cdot [b] = [a \cdot b]$$

Therefore, we get the following.

$$\begin{aligned} [a] \cdot ([b] \cdot [c]) &= [a] \cdot [b \cdot c] \\ &= [a \cdot (b \cdot c)] \\ &= [(a \cdot b) \cdot c] \\ &= [a \cdot b] \cdot [c] \\ &= ([a] \cdot [b]) \cdot [c] \end{aligned}$$

□